

# Kiting

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For many around the world, kites are a childhood joy. Kites were first developed in China around 1000 BCE. Although kites traditionally have only one string and no control, precise manufacturing techniques and materials have made it possible to make steerable kites.

These broadly fall into two categories: delta kites and foil kites. Delta kites have a rigid structure and make a “triangle shape”. These are usually good for maneuvering and making fast turns in the sky, but do not generate much power. Foil kites generate more power, but move more slowly in the sky. These can have two lines, or four lines. The four line kites can be trickier to fly, but provide more control opportunities. The bottom two strings are “brake” lines, which fix those points in the sky as pivots, but normal steering is done using the top lines. Both kites require a good wind (at least 8 miles per hour). To start the kite, set it up and give it a sharp tug. The angle of the delta kite to the ground controls how much air it catches, so these can sometimes fly in lower-wind conditions.

The most important thing is to never panic. Pulling the strings of the kite, even both strings, will make it go faster and higher into the air because it increases the tension in the lines. In case of emergency, let the lines go slack, run forward, and in the worst case, let go of the lines. The kite will not fly away or go very far, it will just fall to the ground.

The mechanics of steering are simple for all kites. Pulling on the left (resp. right) causes the kite to turn left (resp. right). Pulling harder causes a turn with a smaller radius, and if pulled tightly enough, the kite will form a “circle” in the sky. A similar mechanism is the “punch turn”, which can be done by making the line opposite to the side you wish to turn go slack. It creates a tighter “snappier” turn than a normal turn, but can be trickier to master as it is less intuitive.

With this, all basic maneuvers of kites can be performed.

While flying don't worry about the lines twisting together. As long as the sides aren't mixed up (the right handle is red and the left handle is blue, by convention) the lines should not bind and the kite should be able to fly. There are dozens of tricks that can be performed with the kite with practice (Prism kites has tutorials), and certain extreme sports, and overall it is a great hobby for windy days for all ages.